Introduction: Getting started

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Outline

1. What is the Flying Spaghetti Monster?
2. Origins: Henderson’s 2005 open letter
3. Core tenets of Pastafarianism
4. A first argument reconstruction
5. Why it matters

What is the Flying Spaghetti Monster?

- 2005: Bobby Henderson writes an open letter to the Kansas State Board of Education
- Proposes that the universe was created by a **Flying Spaghetti Monster (FSM)**
- If *intelligent design* gets science-class time, the FSM deserves equal time
- The letter goes viral — the **Church of the Flying Spaghetti Monster** is born
- Followers: **Pastafarians** (*pasta* + *Rastafarianism*)

> **Note**
>
> “I and many others around the world are of your belief in a Creator. We just choose a different view of that creator.” — Bobby Henderson, 2005



Origins: The Kansas Controversy (2005)

Background:

- Kansas Board of Education votes to allow *intelligent design* in science class alongside evolution
- Reopens church–state separation debate in public education

Henderson's move:

- Open letter demanding equal class time for FSM creationism (Cho 2023)
- Core claim: if one supernatural creation theory is in, all others must be too
- Effect: the Kansas Board reversed its decision in 2006

Core Beliefs of Pastafarianism

Tenet	Content
Creator	The FSM created the universe “while quite drunk”
Universe age	~5,000 years (evidence hidden to test faith)
Holy figures	Pirates — the original Pastafarians
Moral code	“The Eight I’d Really Rather You Didn’ts”
Afterlife	Beer volcano and stripper factory
Climate change	Caused by the decline of piracy
Ritual dress	Colander worn on the head

Henderson’s Argument — Source View

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[Equal time]: FSM creationism deserves equal time in public school science class.

<Equality argument>

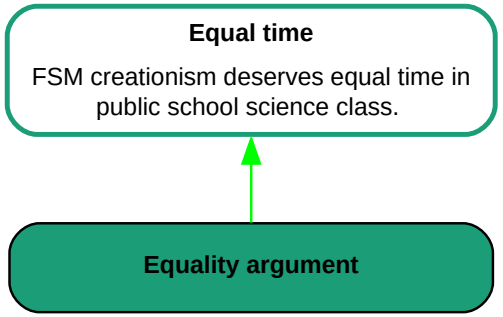
(1) If one supernatural creation theory receives time in public school science classes,
    all others deserve equal time.
(2) Intelligent design received time in Kansas public school science classes.
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(3) [Equal time]
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Henderson’s Argument — Map View

argdown

click to enable zoom!

Source



Why It Matters

Philosophy of religion:

- What *defines* a religion? Belief? Ritual? Community? Cosmology?
- Does a *parodic* origin disqualify a belief system from counting as a religion?

Law: (Martin 2020)

- Courts in the US, Germany, Austria, New Zealand, and Italy have decided Pastafarian cases
- Issues: military exemptions, oath ceremonies, ID photos with colander
- Key question: must beliefs be *sincere* to deserve legal protection?

Summary

- Pastafarianism originated as satirical protest against intelligent design in Kansas (2005)
- It has grown into a movement raising genuine questions about the definition and legal status of religion
- The core question: **does a satirical origin disqualify a belief system from being a religion?**
- Next session: reconstructing the “Is Pastafarianism a religion?” argument in detail

Cho, Hyun Jai (violet). 2023. “Tax Exemptions, Spaghetti, and the Devil: The Perils of Ambiguous Limitations on Religion and a Proposed Definition for Legally Acknowledged Systems of Faith.” *Przegląd Konstytucyjny*, no. 3: 61–82.

Martin, Nick. 2020. “Exemptions, Sincerity and Pastafarianism.” *Journal of Applied Philosophy* 37 (2): 258–72. https://doi.org/10.1111/japp.12386.